Obadiah

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

The shortest book in the Hebrew Scriptures. Twenty-one verses.

And it is about two brothers.

Jacob and Esau, who fought in their mother's womb. Two nations, Yahweh told Rebekah, and the elder will serve the younger.

Esau became Edom, a nation in the red rock mountains south of the Dead Sea, living in cities cut into the cliffs, sure no one could ever reach them.

Who will bring me down to the ground?

And Yahweh answers: though you set your nest among the stars, I will bring you down from there.

The pride of your heart has deceived you.

Because on the day Jerusalem fell, Edom stood on the other side and watched.

Then joined in. Rejoiced. Looted. And stood at the crossroads to catch the ones who escaped.

As you have done, it will be done to you.

And then the turn. On Mount Zion there will be deliverance.

The house of Jacob a fire, the house of Joseph a flame.

Two houses, burning together.

And the last line of the book: the kingdom will be Yahweh's.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

OBADIAH - The Pride of Edom, a Brother Who Watched, and the Kingdom Will Be Yahweh's

Key Notes

- Obadiah means servant of Yahweh. Nothing else is known about him - no father, no town, no king's reign. The vision is the whole of what we have (Obadiah 1:1).
- Edom is Esau. The twins fought in Rebekah's womb, and Yahweh told her two nations were in it and the elder would serve the younger. Obadiah is the last chapter of that rivalry (Obadiah 1:6, 1:10, Genesis 25:23).
- Verses 1 to 9 run closely parallel to Jeremiah 49:7-16, sometimes word for word. Either one prophet drew on the other, or both drew on a word already known. Two witnesses saying the same thing (Obadiah 1:1-9, Jeremiah 49:16).
- "An ambassador is sent among the nations." Yahweh is gathering the nations against Edom. The attack comes from His word before it comes from any army (Obadiah 1:1).
- "I have made you small among the nations." Edom thought itself great. Yahweh calls it small, and speaks as if it were already done (Obadiah 1:2).
- "The pride of your heart has deceived you." Pride is not only a sin. It is a liar. It told Edom it was safe (Obadiah 1:3, Proverbs 16:18).
- Edom's cities were cut into the red sandstone cliffs south of the Dead Sea, reached through narrow gorges. Petra, carved into the rock, later stood in that same country. Who will bring me down? was a reasonable question about the walls. It was a fatal one about the heart (Obadiah 1:3).
- "Though your nest is set among the stars." It echoes the king of Babylon in Isaiah 14: I will exalt my throne above the stars of God. The same pride, and the same answer: brought down (Obadiah 1:4, Isaiah 14:13-15).
- Thieves take only what they want, and grape pickers leave gleanings. What is coming to Edom will leave nothing (Obadiah 1:5, Jeremiah 49:9).
- "The men of your alliance have… deceived you." Edom trusted its allies. They turned on it. The one who betrays a brother is betrayed by friends (Obadiah 1:7).
- "Friends who eat your bread lay a snare under you." The psalm says it of a trusted friend who ate bread with me and lifted up his heel (Obadiah 1:7, Psalm 41:9).
- Teman was a region of Edom famous for its wise men. Eliphaz, one of Job's counselors, was a Temanite. Yahweh will destroy the wise men out of Edom (Obadiah 1:8-9, Job 2:11).
- "For the violence done to your brother Jacob." The word brother is the charge. The Torah had told Israel: you shall not abhor an Edomite, for he is your brother. Edom did not return the kindness (Obadiah 1:10, Deuteronomy 23:7).

- Edom had refused Israel passage through its land on the way out of Egypt and came out with the sword, so Israel went around. The grudge was old (Obadiah 1:10, Numbers 20:18-21).
- “In the day that you stood on the other side.” Standing aloof is the first charge. Watching is where it started (Obadiah 1:11).
- The day in view is most likely the fall of Jerusalem to Babylon. The psalmist by the rivers of Babylon remembered the children of Edom crying: raze it, raze it, even to its foundation (Obadiah 1:11, Psalm 137:7).
- “Even you were like one of them.” A brother who stands by while strangers attack becomes one of the strangers (Obadiah 1:11).
- Eight times Yahweh says don’t - don’t look down, don’t rejoice, don’t speak proudly, don’t enter the gate, don’t look on their affliction, don’t seize their wealth, don’t stand at the crossroads, don’t deliver them up. It runs from watching to gloating to looting to handing over (Obadiah 1:12-14).
- “Don’t rejoice over the children of Judah in the day of their destruction.” Proverbs: do not rejoice when your enemy falls, lest Yahweh see it and it displease Him (Obadiah 1:12, Proverbs 24:17-18).
- “Don’t speak proudly” is literally don’t make your mouth great. Pride again, in the mouth (Obadiah 1:12).
- “The day of Yahweh is near all the nations!” Edom is the example, not the exception. What is said to Edom is said to everyone who does what Edom did (Obadiah 1:15).
- “As you have done, it will be done to you. Your deeds will return upon your own head.” It is the Torah’s measure for measure, and Paul’s whatever a man sows, that he will also reap (Obadiah 1:15, Leviticus 24:19, Galatians 6:7).
- “As you have drunk on my holy mountain” - Edom celebrated on Mount Zion after it fell. Now the nations will drink the cup of Yahweh’s wrath (Obadiah 1:16, Jeremiah 25:15).
- “In Mount Zion, there will be those who escape, and it will be holy.” Joel says the same: in Mount Zion and in Jerusalem there will be those who escape (Obadiah 1:17, Joel 2:32).
- “The house of Jacob will possess their possessions.” What was taken is given back (Obadiah 1:17).
- “The house of Jacob will be a fire, the house of Joseph a flame.” Two houses named side by side, Judah under the name of Jacob and the northern tribes under the name of Joseph, burning together. Ezekiel’s two sticks, Judah and Joseph, become one in Yahweh’s hand (Obadiah 1:18, Ezekiel 37:16).
- “Indeed, Yahweh has spoken.” The fire is not Jacob’s idea. It is Yahweh’s word (Obadiah 1:18).
- The returning people spread out in every direction: the South takes Esau’s mountain, the lowland takes Philistia, Ephraim and Samaria are possessed, Benjamin takes Gilead. The land is given back whole (Obadiah 1:19-20).

- Sepharad is an unknown place, perhaps Sardis in Asia Minor. Later Jews used the name for Spain, which is where the word Sephardic comes from (Obadiah 1:20).
- “Saviors will go up on Mount Zion.” The word is the one used for the judges Yahweh raised up to save Israel: you gave them saviors who saved them out of the hands of their adversaries (Obadiah 1:21, Nehemiah 9:27).
- “The kingdom will be Yahweh’s.” The whole book has been about a nation that thought it could not be brought down. It ends with the only kingdom that will not be. Revelation hears the same announcement: the kingdom of the world has become the Kingdom of our Lord and of His Messiah (Obadiah 1:21, Psalm 22:28, Revelation 11:15).
- Edom as a nation disappeared. Its people, the Idumeans, were later absorbed into Judea, and King Herod the Great, who tried to kill the infant Yahshua, was an Idumean. Esau against Jacob one last time (Obadiah 1:18, Matthew 2:16).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Pride of Your Heart	Obadiah 1:3 • Jeremiah 49:16 • Proverbs 16:18
Above the Stars of God	Obadiah 1:4 • Isaiah 14:13-15
Gleanings Left	Obadiah 1:5 • Jeremiah 49:9
Two Nations in the Womb	Obadiah 1:10 • Genesis 25:23 • Genesis 27:40
He Is Your Brother	Obadiah 1:10 • Deuteronomy 23:7 • Numbers 20:18-21
Remember the Day of Jerusalem	Obadiah 1:11 • Psalm 137:7 • Ezekiel 35:15
Do Not Rejoice When Your Enemy Falls	Obadiah 1:12 • Proverbs 24:17-18 • Ezekiel 25:12
As You Have Done	Obadiah 1:15 • Leviticus 24:19 • Galatians 6:7

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Cup of Wrath for the Nations	Obadiah 1:16 • Jeremiah 25:15 • Isaiah 51:22
Those Who Escape on Mount Zion	Obadiah 1:17 • Joel 2:32 • Isaiah 4:3
Jacob a Fire, Joseph a Flame	Obadiah 1:18 • Ezekiel 37:16 • Zechariah 10:6
Possessing the Remnant of Edom	Obadiah 1:19 • Amos 9:11-12 • Isaiah 11:14
Saviors on Mount Zion	Obadiah 1:21 • Nehemiah 9:27 • Isaiah 19:20
The Kingdom Is Yahweh’s	Obadiah 1:21 • Psalm 22:28 • Zechariah 14:9

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- Enduring Word - Obadiah Commentary (David Guzik) - verse by verse through the judgment of Edom and the deliverance of Zion
- BibleProject - Obadiah Overview - a short video on Edom, Jacob and Esau, and the day of Yahweh

Obadiah 1 - Opening Intro

Obadiah is the shortest book in the Old Testament. One chapter, twenty-one verses. And the whole thing is about two brothers.

Go back to Genesis 25. Rebekah is pregnant with twins, and they are fighting inside her. And Yahweh tells her: two nations are in your womb, and the older will serve the younger.

Jacob and Esau. Jacob became Israel. Esau became Edom.

And Edom settled in the mountains south of the Dead Sea - red rock country - and built its cities right into the cliffs. Narrow canyons. Walls of stone. You could hold off an army with a handful of men.

So Edom says in its heart: who will bring me down to the ground?

And Yahweh answers: the pride of your heart has deceived you.

Hear that. Pride is a liar. It does not just make you sin. It tells you that you are safe. It told Edom nobody could touch it.

Though you soar like the eagle, though your nest is among the stars - I will bring you down from there.

And then Yahweh tells Edom why. For the violence done to your brother Jacob.

Your brother. That is the charge. The Torah told Israel: do not hate an Edomite, he is your brother. And when Jerusalem fell, Edom did not act like a brother.

Listen to how it happened, because the steps matter.

First, in the day strangers carried Jerusalem away, you stood on the other side. You just watched.

And then it gets worse. Do not look down on your brother in the day of his disaster. Do not rejoice. Do not boast. Do not go into the gate. Do not take his wealth. Do not stand at the crossroads to cut off the ones trying to escape. Do not hand over the survivors.

Watching. Then gloating. Then looting. Then handing them over.

That is how it goes with a brother you have not forgiven. It starts with standing off to the side when he falls. And if the bitterness is not dealt with, it ends at the crossroads, blocking his escape.

And the psalm remembers it. By the rivers of Babylon: remember, Yahweh, the children of Edom, who said in the day of Jerusalem - tear it down, tear it down to the foundation.

And then the line that should stop every one of us. As you have done, it will be done to you. Your deeds will come back on your own head.

But Obadiah does not end on Edom. He turns.

On Mount Zion there will be deliverance, and it will be holy. And the house of Jacob will possess what belongs to it.

And then: the house of Jacob will be a fire, and the house of Joseph a flame.

Two houses. Jacob and Joseph. Judah and the northern tribes - side by side, burning together. That is Ezekiel 37, the two sticks, Judah and Joseph, joined into one in Yahweh's hand.

And the exiles come home from every direction and possess the land again.

And the very last line of the book: saviors will go up on Mount Zion, and the kingdom will be Yahweh's.

Edom thought it was the kingdom that could not fall. The book ends with the only kingdom that never will.

And here is the epilogue history wrote. Edom as a nation disappeared. Its people got absorbed into Judea and called Idumeans. And an Idumean named Herod became king - and tried to kill a baby in Bethlehem. Esau against Jacob, one last time.

Before we read - ask yourself where you stood the last time your brother fell. On the other side? Or right next to him?

Obadiah 1:1-21 (WEB)

1 The vision of Obadiah. This is what the Lord Yahweh says about Edom. We have heard news from Yahweh, and an ambassador is sent among the nations, saying, "Arise, and let's rise up against her in battle.

2 Behold, I have made you small among the nations. You are greatly despised.

3 The pride of your heart has deceived you, you who dwell in the clefts of the rock, whose habitation is high, who says in his heart, 'Who will bring me down to the ground?'[1]

4 Though you mount on high as the eagle, and though your nest is set among the stars, I will bring you down from there," says Yahweh.[2]

5 "If thieves came to you, if robbers by night—oh, what disaster awaits you—wouldn't they only steal until they had enough? If grape pickers came to you, wouldn't they leave some gleaning grapes?[3]

---

[1] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 49:16 • Proverbs 16:18 - *the pride of your heart has deceived you, you who dwell in the clefts of the rock, and pride goes before destruction*

[2] **Cross-Reference:** Isaiah 14:13-15 - *I will exalt my throne above the stars of God, yet you shall be brought down*

[3] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 49:9 - *grape gatherers leaving gleanings, and thieves taking only what they want*

6 How Esau will be ransacked! How his hidden treasures are sought out!

7 All the men of your alliance have brought you on your way, even to the border. The men who were at peace with you have deceived you, and prevailed against you. Friends who eat your bread lay a snare under you. There is no understanding in him."

8 "Won't I in that day", says Yahweh, "destroy the wise men out of Edom, and understanding out of the mountain of Esau?

9 Your mighty men, Teman, will be dismayed, to the end that everyone may be cut off from the mountain of Esau by slaughter.

10 For the violence done to your brother Jacob, shame will cover you, and you will be cut off forever.[4]

11 In the day that you stood on the other side, in the day that strangers carried away his substance, and foreigners entered into his gates, and cast lots for Jerusalem, even you were like one of them.[5]

12 But don't look down on your brother in the day of his disaster, and don't rejoice over the children of Judah in the day of their destruction. Don't speak proudly in the day of distress.[6]

13 Don't enter into the gate of my people in the day of their calamity. Don't look down on their affliction in the day of their calamity, neither seize their wealth on the day of their calamity.

14 Don't stand in the crossroads to cut off those of his who escape. Don't deliver up those of his who remain in the day of distress.

15 For the day of Yahweh is near all the nations! As you have done, it will be done to you. Your deeds will return upon your own head.[7]

16 For as you have drunk on my holy mountain, so will all the nations drink continually. Yes, they will drink, swallow down, and will be as though they had not been.[8]

17 But in Mount Zion, there will be those who escape, and it will be holy. The house of Jacob will possess their possessions.[9]

---

[4] **Cross-Reference:** Genesis 25:23 • Deuteronomy 23:7 - *two nations in your womb, the elder serving the younger, and you shall not abhor an Edomite, for he is your brother*

[5] **Cross-Reference:** Psalm 137:7 • Numbers 20:18-21 - *remember against the children of Edom the day of Jerusalem, and Edom refusing Israel passage with the sword*

[6] **Cross-Reference:** Proverbs 24:17-18 • Ezekiel 35:15 - *do not rejoice when your enemy falls, and as you rejoiced over Israel's desolation, so will I do to you*

[7] **Cross-Reference:** Leviticus 24:19 • Galatians 6:7 - *as he has done, so shall it be done to him, and whatever a man sows, that he will also reap*

[8] **Messianic Connection:** Jeremiah 25:15 • Isaiah 51:22 - *the cup of the wine of wrath given to the nations, and the cup of staggering taken out of Zion's hand*

[9] **Messianic Connection:** Joel 2:32 • Isaiah 4:3 - *in Mount Zion there will be those who escape, and he who is left in Zion shall be called holy*

18 The house of Jacob will be a fire, the house of Joseph a flame, and the house of Esau for stubble.
They will burn among them, and devour them. There will not be any remaining to the house of Esau."
Indeed, Yahweh has spoken.[10]

19 Those of the South will possess the mountain of Esau, and those of the lowland, the Philistines. They
will possess the field of Ephraim, and the field of Samaria. Benjamin will possess Gilead.[11]

20 The captives of this army of the children of Israel, who are among the Canaanites, will possess even
to Zarephath; and the captives of Jerusalem, who are in Sepharad, will possess the cities of the Negev.

21 Saviors will go up on Mount Zion to judge the mountains of Esau, and the kingdom will be Yahweh's.[12]

---

[10] **Messianic Connection:** Ezekiel 37:16 • Zechariah 10:6 - *one stick for Judah and one for Joseph, and I will strengthen the house of Judah and save the house of Joseph*

[11] **Messianic Connection:** Amos 9:11-12 • Isaiah 11:14 - *the fallen tent of David raised up to possess the remnant of Edom, and power extended over Edom and Moab*

[12] **Messianic Connection:** Nehemiah 9:27 • Psalm 22:28 • Zechariah 14:9 - *saviors given who saved them from their adversaries, the kingdom is Yahweh's, and Yahweh King over all the earth*

Major Themes in Obadiah

- Two brothers whose rivalry began in the womb
- Pride that deceives, promising a safety it cannot give
- A nest among the stars, and a fall from there
- Allies who betray the one who betrayed his brother
- Wisdom destroyed out of Teman
- Brother as the charge: the violence done to Jacob
- Standing on the other side, the first step
- Watching, gloating, looting, handing over
- Rejoicing over a brother's fall
- The day of Yahweh near to all the nations
- As you have done, it will be done to you
- The cup drunk on the holy mountain, and the cup of wrath
- Deliverance and holiness on Mount Zion
- The house of Jacob a fire and the house of Joseph a flame
- Exiles returning to possess the land again
- Saviors going up on Mount Zion
- The kingdom that will be Yahweh's

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May we see through the lies our pride tells us.

May we never build our nest so high that we forget who can bring it down.

May we never stand on the other side when our brother falls.

May we never rejoice over another's disaster.

May we deal with our bitterness before it walks us to the crossroads.

May we remember that what we do will return on our own heads.

May we be found among those who escape on Mount Zion.

May we be holy, as the mountain will be holy.

May Judah and Joseph burn together as one fire.

May everything that was taken be given back.

May we long for the day the kingdom is Yahweh's.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.